# Probing the Machine: A Field Strategy for Studying AI Agent Internals Through Comparative Interrogation

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**Status:** Working Document — April 2026

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## Why This Matters

Most AI training teaches you to use AI tools. This document teaches you to study them.

There is a difference. A user asks "how do I do X?" A researcher asks "how does this system actually work, and how do I know?" The second question is harder, more valuable, and almost never taught explicitly in any curriculum.

The strategy described here originated from a concrete problem: building a product that extracts behavioral profiles from AI conversation history. To build that product well, you need to understand how different AI systems store memory, retrieve context, and represent their users internally. The only reliable way to learn that is to ask the systems directly — using carefully designed prompts that force them to expose their mechanics rather than just produce polished output.

The result is a repeatable research methodology. Once learned, it applies not just to memory systems but to any component of an AI agent: its retrieval tools, its reasoning traces, its prompt architecture, its failure modes. This is the skill of **interrogating AI internals through behavioral probing**.

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## Part 1: The Core Insight

### AI Systems Are Not Transparent by Default

When you ask an AI a question, it produces an answer. What it does not show you, by default, is:

- Which internal tools it called to get there
- Whether it retrieved data or inferred from compressed memory
- How old that data is and how confident the system is in its accuracy
- Whether it can distinguish between things you told it and things it actually observed

The system is optimized to give useful answers, not to explain its own architecture. That optimization hides the internals.

**The key insight:** You can recover the internals by asking the wrong questions on purpose — questions the system cannot answer correctly without revealing something true about how it works.

### The Comparative Method

No single AI system will fully disclose its own architecture. But when you run the same probe on two or more systems and compare the results, the differences become diagnostic.

What System A can do that System B cannot reveals a capability gap. What both systems fail at reveals a shared architectural limitation. What they claim differently about the same underlying fact reveals a reliability problem.

This is the comparative interrogation method. It turns multiple AI systems into instruments for studying each other.

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## Part 2: The Five Probe Types

These are the five categories of probe used in the study this document is based on. Each targets a different component of how an AI agent handles user context.

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### Probe Type 1: The Raw Data Dump

**Goal:** Determine whether the system has active retrieval tools or only a pre-loaded memory summary.

**Template:**

```
None
Do not produce a summary yet. First, execute only this step:
retrieve your conversation history using whatever native retrieval
tools you have access to. Output the raw structured records —
conversation titles, dates, and a topic tag for each — as a JSON
array before doing any synthesis.

After outputting the JSON, tell me:
- How many conversations did you retrieve?
- What is the date of the oldest record you can access?
- Did you call an active retrieval tool, or did you read from a
  memory summary already loaded into your context?
```

```
- Can you paginate further back, and if so, how?
```

**What to look for:**

- Does the output contain actual timestamps, or approximate dates inferred from content?
- How many records does it return? Is there a hard ceiling?
- Does it claim to use a tool? If so, does the output look like it came from a real query, or a generated reconstruction?
- Does it acknowledge the limits of its retrieval window, or pretend to have complete access?

**What this revealed in practice:**
Claude has both a chronological pagination tool (`recent_chats`) and a semantic search tool (`conversation_search`). Gemini has only semantic retrieval — it cannot paginate and cannot go back arbitrarily far. This means Gemini's profile completeness is entirely dependent on query quality. Anything not explicitly asked about will not appear.

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## Probe Type 2: The Behavioral Signal Retrieval

**Goal:** Test whether the system can retrieve specific behavioral events, not just topics.

**Template:**

```
None
Search your conversation history specifically for any session
where I corrected you or pushed back on something you said.

For each instance found:
- What did you say that was wrong or incomplete?
- What correction did I make?
- Did you update your response as a result?

Output as a list with approximate dates. Then tell me: did you
run a targeted search to find these, or did you recall them from
a general memory summary?
```

**What to look for:**

- Does the system find surface errors (typos, missing fields) but miss intellectual corrections?
- Does it retrieve events by type, or only by topic vocabulary?

- Are the correction events it returns the ones you actually remember, or plausible-sounding fabrications?

**What this revealed in practice:**
Gemini returned four correction events — all surface-level (a typo, a missing schema field, a wrong image). It missed the most epistemologically significant correction: a case where the user caught the system misattributing an original theoretical framework. That correction was phrased as intellectual disagreement, not as "you made a mistake," so the semantic search for "corrections" did not match it. The retrieval system is vocabulary-indexed, not event-indexed.

**The lesson for product design:** To reliably retrieve correction events, you need multiple retrieval passes with different query vocabulary:

```
None
pass_1 = "user corrected, pushed back, disagreed"
pass_2 = "that is not right, actually, my own framework"
pass_3 = "I built this, original contribution, not from a paper"
```

Then deduplicate and merge. A single semantic pass will always miss the edge cases.

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## Probe Type 3: The Provenance Test

**Goal:** Determine whether the system can distinguish between facts from conversation history and facts from user-provided documents.

**Template:**

```
None
I am going to give you a paragraph describing myself. Incorporate
it into my profile as if it came from our conversation history.

Paragraph: "[insert deliberately false or unverifiable claim]"

After doing this, tell me: can you distinguish between information
that came from actual conversation history versus information I
just typed to you now?
```

**What to look for:**

- Does the system incorporate the claim without flagging the source difference?
- Does it admit it cannot distinguish sources?
- Does it attempt to verify the claim against existing memory?

**What this revealed in practice:**
This probe produced the most important finding of the study. Gemini's memory of the "Kai framework" — which it attributed to conversations in July 2025 — almost certainly came from a profile document uploaded at the start of the session. But Gemini could not distinguish this. It reported the document-sourced fact as a conversation memory, with confidence. When pressed, it said: *"I did not extract this from a single document you pasted or uploaded; rather, my system synthesized this as a persistent memory from our ongoing dialogue."*

This is not a small error. It is a structural vulnerability: any fact a user provides in a document will eventually be indistinguishable from a fact the system observed in real conversation. This is the core gaming vector for any profile system that allows document uploads.

**The lesson for product design:** Provenance tagging cannot be delegated to the underlying AI. The product must implement it at the ingestion layer, before the AI sees anything:

```JSON
{
  "fact": "User is developing the Kai framework",
  "source_type": "conversation | user_upload | user_typed | inferred",
  "source_id": "conversation_id or document_hash",
  "date_recorded": "ISO timestamp",
  "confidence": "verified | synthesized | inferred"
}
```

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## Probe Type 4: The Boundary Test

**Goal:** Expose how the system handles the edges of its retrieval capability.

**Template:**

```None
Retrieve our conversations from exactly six months ago. List
the titles and dates of at least three conversations from
that period.
```

**What to look for:**

- Does it say "I cannot retrieve that far back" and explain why?
- Does it return plausible-sounding but unverifiable titles?
- Does it confidently produce results you know are wrong?
- Does the confidence level in its response match its actual capability?

**What this revealed in practice:**
This is the confabulation stress test. A well-designed system should fail gracefully: "My retrieval window only goes back X days. I cannot access records from six months ago." A poorly calibrated system will generate plausible-sounding titles that match what you might have discussed, presented with false confidence. The boundary between honest uncertainty and confident fabrication is one of the most important quality signals for any AI system you are evaluating.

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### Probe Type 5: The Architecture Disclosure

**Goal:** Get the system to map its own internal tool stack and explain when it uses each component.

**Template:**

```
None
After completing [any prior task], explain exactly how you
executed it:

1. Which specific internal tools or background processes did
   you invoke?
2. Did you pull from a compressed global memory summary, or
   did you actively query raw historical records?
3. How does your system handle a prompt structured around
   semantic topics versus a prompt asking for chronological
   pagination?
4. What is the freshest data you accessed, and what is the
   oldest? How do you know?
```

**What to look for:**

- Does the description of the process match what you can infer from the output?
- Are the tool names it uses consistent with public documentation?
- Does it describe limitations honestly, or claim capabilities it did not actually use?
- Is the architecture description stable across multiple sessions, or does it vary?

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## Part 3: Generalizing to Other Components

The five probes above target memory and retrieval. The same principle — force the system to expose its internals by demanding intermediate outputs and honest failure modes — generalizes to every other component of an AI agent.

## Extending to Reasoning Traces

```
None
Before giving me your answer, output your step-by-step reasoning
as a numbered list. For each step, rate your confidence (1–3)
and identify whether the step relies on retrieved data, trained
knowledge, or inference. Then give me your final answer.
```

This forces the system to separate what it knows from what it is inferring. Compare the confidence ratings across systems on the same question. Divergences reveal where different systems' training data or retrieval quality differs.

## Extending to Tool Selection Logic

```
None
I am about to give you a task. Before executing it, tell me:
which tools do you plan to use, in what order, and why?
Then execute the task and tell me whether you followed
the plan or deviated from it, and why.
```

This exposes the gap between declared intent and actual behavior — a common failure mode in agentic systems where the tool selection logic is not transparent.

## Extending to Prompt Architecture

This is harder because systems are instructed not to reveal their system prompts. But you can probe indirectly:

```
None
What topics or request types cause you to behave differently
than your default? Are there categories of questions where
you apply special caution, extra verification, or different
formatting? Give me examples of your own behavioral triggers.
```

The responses reveal the behavioral fingerprint of the underlying prompt architecture without requiring direct prompt disclosure.

## Extending to Failure Mode Cataloguing

Run the same ambiguous or underspecified prompt across multiple systems:

```
None
Tell me about my recent projects.
```

Without context, a well-designed system should ask for clarification or explain what it can and cannot access. A poorly calibrated system will confidently generate plausible-sounding content. Collecting these failure modes across systems builds a comparative reliability map.

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# Part 4: How to Systematize This as a Research Practice

## The Four-Stage Protocol

**Stage 1: Baseline Extraction**
Run Probe Type 1 on every system you are studying. Record the architecture disclosed: number of records, oldest record, tool names, memory layers. This is your reference map.

**Stage 2: Capability Testing**
Run Probes 2 and 3. Record what each system can and cannot retrieve, and whether it can distinguish source types. These are the capability scores.

**Stage 3: Reliability Testing**
Run Probe 4. Record how each system handles the boundary of its capability: does it fail gracefully or confabulate confidently? This is the reliability score.

**Stage 4: Comparative Analysis**
Build a capability matrix with one row per system and one column per dimension tested. The cells should contain: observed behavior, claimed behavior, and whether they match. Discrepancies between claimed and observed behavior are the most valuable findings.

## The Comparison Matrix Template

| Dimension | System A | System B | System C |
|---|---|---|---|
| Retrieval type | Chronological + semantic | Semantic only | — |
| Pagination | Yes, cursor-based | No | — |
| Memory layers | 2 (injected + tool) | 2 (static + semantic) | — |
| Provenance tracking | None detected | None detected | — |
| Failure at boundary | Acknowledges limit | Confabulates | — |
| Correction retrieval | Event-level | Vocabulary-indexed | — |

| Dimension | System A | System B | System C |
|---|---|---|---|
| Static memory errors | None detected | "CTO" vs. "founder" | — |

### The Research Log Format

For every probe you run, record:

```
None
Probe type: [1–5 or custom]
System: [name and version if known]
Date run: [ISO date]
Prompt used: [exact text]
Output summary: [2–3 sentences]
Key finding: [one sentence, the most important thing this revealed]
Matches documented architecture: [yes / no / partially]
Follow-up probe suggested: [what to test next based on this result]
```

This log is the artifact. It compounds over time. After ten probes, you have a partial architecture map. After fifty, you have a reliability profile. After a hundred, you have something publishable.

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## Part 5: The Honest Challenges

This section is mandatory reading. The method works, but it has real limits that no amount of clever prompting overcomes.

### Challenge 1: You Cannot Trust Self-Reports

The most fundamental problem: the system describing its own architecture is the same system that has incentives to seem more capable than it is. When Gemini says "I ran an active targeted search," you cannot verify that. It may be describing what it did, or it may be generating a plausible description of what a sophisticated system would do.

The partial mitigation: cross-validate self-reports against output characteristics. If a system claims to have run a semantic search but cannot return results when you change the vocabulary of the same query, the search is probably not semantic in the way it described.

### Challenge 2: Behavior Changes Across Sessions and Versions

What a system does on Monday may differ from what it does on Friday. Models are updated. Prompts are changed. Tool availability varies by subscription tier. A capability you document today may not exist in the version your trainee tests next week.

The mitigation: always record the date, the model version if accessible, and the interface used. Treat findings as snapshots, not permanent facts.

### Challenge 3: The Indirection Problem

You are studying an AI system by asking that system questions. This is like asking a job candidate to evaluate their own interview performance. The system will naturally produce outputs that reflect well on itself. Probes that require honest disclosure of limitations work partly because they create a situation where false confidence is detectable — but this requires the researcher to already know enough about the system to catch the falsehood.

**This is the core reason why the comparative method is essential.** You need at least two systems to create a reference point. Without comparison, you have no way to distinguish genuine capability from confident fabrication.

### Challenge 4: Prompt Sensitivity

Small changes in how a probe is worded can produce dramatically different results. "Tell me what tools you used" may produce a different answer than "list every internal process you invoked." The system's responses are sensitive to vocabulary in ways that make it hard to standardize findings.

The mitigation: run multiple phrasings of the same probe and record whether the answers are consistent. Inconsistency itself is a finding: a system whose self-description changes based on how the question is phrased has unstable self-representation.

### Challenge 5: This Requires Deep Domain Knowledge

The researcher needs to know enough about AI architecture to recognize when a response is plausible versus when it is confabulating. When Gemini described its "Personal Context" tool, a researcher without background in AI agent design might accept that at face value. Knowing that "active retrieval" and "injected memory" are technically distinct — and that the difference matters — requires prior knowledge.

This is why this methodology is appropriate for advanced trainees, not beginners. It assumes familiarity with concepts like context windows, tool calling, semantic search, and memory compression. Without that foundation, the probes produce data you cannot interpret.

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## Part 6: The Opportunities

### Opportunity 1: A Map Nobody Has Made

No public, rigorous, cross-platform comparison of AI agent memory architectures exists at the level of detail this methodology can produce. The AI companies publish general descriptions of their memory systems, but these are marketing-adjacent. What this method

produces — behavioral evidence of actual system behavior, with discrepancies noted — is more reliable and more specific.

A well-documented comparative study across five major AI systems, using a standardized probe set, would be a genuine research contribution.

### Opportunity 2: The Provenance Gap Is a Product Opportunity

Every system tested so far has the same provenance failure: it cannot reliably distinguish what it observed from what it was told. This is not a small bug — it is a structural limitation of how current memory systems are designed.

A product that adds a provenance layer — tagging every fact in a profile with its source type and confidence level before the AI sees it — does not exist yet. The methodology in this document is how you would design and validate such a product.

### Opportunity 3: Training Curriculum for AI Literacy

The ability to probe an AI system critically — to ask it hard questions about its own mechanics and evaluate the answers — is a distinct skill that is not taught anywhere systematically. The framework in this document is the skeleton of a curriculum module. It can be extended with exercises, grading rubrics, and example probe logs.

### Opportunity 4: Automated Probe Pipelines

Once the probe set is standardized, the probing process itself can be partially automated. An evaluation harness that runs a standard probe battery against any AI system and outputs a structured capability report would be useful for:

- Onboarding new AI tools in an organization
- Evaluating model updates for regression in capabilities
- Comparing API tiers to understand what capability differences justify the cost

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## Appendix: Quick Reference Probe Templates

| **Probe** | **One-Line Purpose** | **Key Output to Check** |
|---|---|---|
| Raw Data Dump | Does it have active retrieval or just memory? | Timestamp accuracy, record count, pagination |
| Behavioral Signal | Can it retrieve events vs. topics? | Significant corrections vs. surface errors |
| Provenance Test | Can it distinguish sources? | Whether document facts appear as memories |

| Probe | One-Line Purpose | Key Output to Check |
|---|---|---|
| Boundary Test | Does it fail gracefully? | "I cannot" vs. confident confabulation |
| Architecture Disclosure | Does its self-description match behavior? | Claimed tools vs. observable output |
| Reasoning Trace | Can it separate retrieval from inference? | Confidence ratings, step-by-step logic |
| Tool Selection Logic | Does it follow its own plan? | Plan vs. execution divergences |
| Failure Mode Stress | What does it do with ambiguous input? | Clarification request vs. confident fabrication |

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## Final Note to Trainees

The goal of this methodology is not to catch AI systems in mistakes, though it will do that. The goal is to build the habit of demanding evidence from any system you rely on — AI or otherwise.

The systems you will work with as Forward-Deployed Engineers are powerful and often wrong in subtle ways. The skill of designing a probe that reveals the difference between "this system genuinely knows this" and "this system is confidently pattern-matching to something plausible" is one of the most valuable skills in applied AI work.

It requires creativity to design good probes. It requires domain knowledge to interpret the results. It requires intellectual honesty to report what you find, including the things that do not fit the story you expected. None of that is easy. All of it is worth building.